The Aztecs were a rich and mighty nation in the country we now call Mexico. The Spanish hoped to conquer this great nation and obtain their gold. Spain sent Hernando Cortez to Mexico. He became the conqueror of this early Mexican civilization.

Read and trace the map and the key words.

conquistador a leader in the Spanish conquest of America

empire people ruled by a powerful person such as an emperor

suspicious questionable behavior causing distrust

fugitive a person running from unfavorable circumstances

interpreter a person who translates for people who speak different languages

suppress to vanquish or subdue

alliances an association to further the interests of its members

siege a military blockade used to force surrender

smallpox a highly contagious and deadly disease causing high fever and sores

corrupt dishonest, especially with a position of power

revolt to rise in rebellion

Hernando Cortez was the Spanish conquistador responsible for the overthrow of Mexico's powerful Aztec Empire. Cortez was born in 1485, in Medellin, Spain. At the young age of 14, he studied law at the University of Salamanca. Then at the age of 18, Cortez joined the Spanish Army under the command of Diego Velázquez. Together, they led the conquest of Cuba. Cortez quickly became Velázquez's favorite. Velázquez wanted Cortez to command a voyage to Mexico to establish a colony and search for gold. Soon, however, he canceled the mission. Velázquez became suspicious of Cortez's loyalties to him. Velázquez, afraid of Cortez becoming the leader of the new colony, sent men to murder him. Cortez found out about the plot against him, and was able to convince his attackers to join him. Cortez set out on his voyage without the permission of the governor and commander, Velázquez. As a fugitive, Cortez made his voyage to the coast of Mexico into the town of Tabasco. There he suppressed the people and took many hostages. One of these hostages was a woman named

1. Hernando C_____ was a Spanish conquistador.

2. At the age of 18, Cortez joined the Spanish Army under D_____ V_____

3. Cortez and Velázquez conquered C_____.

4. Cortez was sent to Mexico to establish a C_____ and search for G_____.

5. Velázquez no longer trusted Cortez so he sent men to M_____ him.

6. On the Coast of Mexico, Cortez overtook the town of T_____.

7. In Tabasco, he took M_____ hostage.

Cortez	Cuba	murder
Diego	Tabasco	gold
colony	Velázquez	Malinche

Fill in the blanks with words from the Word Bank.

____ 1. Hernando Cortez is famous for his conquest of the Aztec Empire.

____ 2. Diego Velázquez and Hernando Cortez overthrew the Spanish government.

____ 3. Velázquez no longer trusted Hernando to set up a colony in Mexico.

____ 4. Hernando was born in Mexico.

____ 5. Cortez joined the Spanish Army at the age of 18.

____ 6. Velázquez sent his men to try to murder Cortez.

____ 7. Cortez convinced his attackers to join his forces.

____ 8. Malinche was Cortez's wife from Spain.

____ 9. Cortez was looking for gold.

Write T for true or F for false in the blank next to each question.

_____ 1. Hernando Cortez is famous for his conquest of
T the Aztec Empire.

_____ 2. Diego Velázquez and Hernando Cortez
F overthrew the Spanish government.

_____ 3. Velázquez no longer trusted Hernando to set up
T a colony in Mexico.

_____ 4. Hernando was born in Mexico.
F

_____ 5. Cortez joined the Spanish Army at the age of
T 18.

_____ 6. Velázquez sent his men to try to murder Cortez.
T

_____ 7. Cortez convinced his attackers to join his forces.
T

_____ 8. Malinche was Cortez's wife from Spain.
F

_____ 9. Cortez was looking for gold.
T

1. ZORTEC _____

2. QUCNOTSRADIO _____

3. YOVGEA _____

4. TACZE _____

5. TSBCOAA _____

6. LINAHCME _____

7. ZLAVEUEQZ _____

8. UBCA _____

9. IGIUFTVE _____

10. PEIRME _____

conquistador	Cuba	empire
Tabasco	Aztec	Malinche
Velázquez	voyage	Cortez
fugitive		

Unscramble the words to match the words in the Word Bank.

After the siege of the town of Tabasco, Hernando faced many challenges with the natives of Mexico. One of these was communicating with the Aztecs. Malinche became the solution to this problem. By translating for Cortez, Malinche helped him for alliances with the Tlaxcala Indians, who were resentful towards the Aztecs due to constant fighting and fear of a future overthrow.

Many also believed Cortez was the mythic god, Quetzalcoatl. Believing Cortez was this god, the Tlaxcala Indians joined his forces. With word spreading of the return of the god, Montezuma, the leader of the Aztecs, and his people prepared their palace in the capital city of Tenochtitlan for Cortez and his men. Along with the help of 3,000 Tlaxcala Indians, Cortez easily took the emperor Montezuma hostage. Cortez felt this was insurance against a revolt from the Aztec people. However, Montezuma's people felt he had given in to Cortez too easily and betrayed him. They stoned him and Montezuma died from his injuries. Cortez failed to overthrow the Aztec Empire in June of 1520.

1. Malinche helped Cortez communicate with the Indians.

2. The Tlaxcala Indians joined forces with Cortez.

3. The Aztecs believed Cortez was Quetzalcoatl, a mythic god.

4. Cortez made his way into the capital city of the Aztecs, Tenochtitlan.

5. Montezuma, the Aztec Emperor, was taken hostage in his own palace.

6. Cortez believed taking Montezuma hostage would prevent a revolt.

7. Montezuma's people betrayed him and stoned him to death.

8. In 1520, Cortez did not overthrow the Aztec Empire.

1. _____ helped Cortez form alliances with the Indians by translating for him.

2. The _____ _____ were resentful towards the Aztecs due to fear of an overthrow.

3. Cortez was able to enter the capital city because the Aztecs believed he was Quetzalcoatl, the mythic _____.

4. _____, the Aztec Emperor, welcomed Cortez into his palace for this reason.

5. Cortez took Montezuma hostage thinking it would prevent a

   _____.

6. Montezuma's people _____ him to death.

7. Cortez _____ at his first attempt to overtake the Aztec Empire.

failed	stoned
Montezuma	revolt
Malinche	god
Tlaxcala Indians	

Fill in the blanks with words from the Word Bank.

1. _____ helped Cortez form alliances with the Indians by translating for him. **Malinche**

2. The _____ _____ were resentful towards the Aztecs due to fear of an overthrow.
Tlaxcala **Indians**

3. Cortez was able to enter the capital city because the Aztecs believed he was Quetzalcoatl, the mythic _____.
god

4. _____, the Aztec Emperor, welcomed Cortez into his palace for this reason. **Montezuma**

5. Cortez took Montezuma hostage thinking it would prevent a _____.
revolt

6. Montezuma's people _____ him to death.
stoned

7. Cortez _____ at his first attempt to overtake the Aztec Empire. **failed**

failed	stoned
Montezuma	revolt
Malinche	god
Tlaxcala Indians	

Cortez's first failed attempt to rule the Aztecs did not discourage him. In the summer of 1521, he reassembled his men and returned to the city. Weakened by smallpox, brought by the Europeans, the Aztec's military was struggling to survive. Cortez easily overpowered the Aztecs using his horses and weapons made of steel. The primitive weapons of the Aztecs were no match for the modern day weapons of the Spaniards. Cortez besieged the city from May to August and captured their new ruler, Cuauhtémoc.

Hernando Cortez eventually overtook the city, and the Aztec empire was no more. Over the ruins of the empire, Cortez began building Mexico City. This became a popular area for many Europeans to come and live, and the most important European city in North America.

Cortez	weakened the Aztec military
smallpox	conquered the Aztec Empire
horses & steel weapons	weapons used by the Spaniards
Cuauhtém	built over the ruins of the Aztec capitol
Mexico City	new emperor of the Aztecs

Cortez

Q-13

Trace the key words and match them to their descriptions.

Cortez

smallpox

horses & steel weapons

Cuauhtém

Mexico City

weakened the Aztec military

conquered the Aztec Empire

weapons used by the Spaniards

built over the ruins of the Aztec capitol

new emperor of the Aztecs

1. _____ overthrew the Aztec empire in 1521.

Malinche Cortez Tlaxcala Indians

2. The Aztec military was weakened by_____.

headaches smallpox chickenpox

3. The Spaniards had _____ that helped them overcome the Aztecs.

horses missiles airplanes

4._____ was the emperor after Montezuma.

Cuauhtémoc Hernando Cortez Velazquez

5._____ was built over the ruins of the Aztec empire and was the most important European city of Northern America.

Tenochtitlan Mexico City Cancun

Circle the correct answer for each blank.

1. _____ overthrew the Aztec empire in 1521.

Malinche Cortez Tlaxcala Indians

2. The Aztec military was weakened by_____.

headaches smallpox chickenpox

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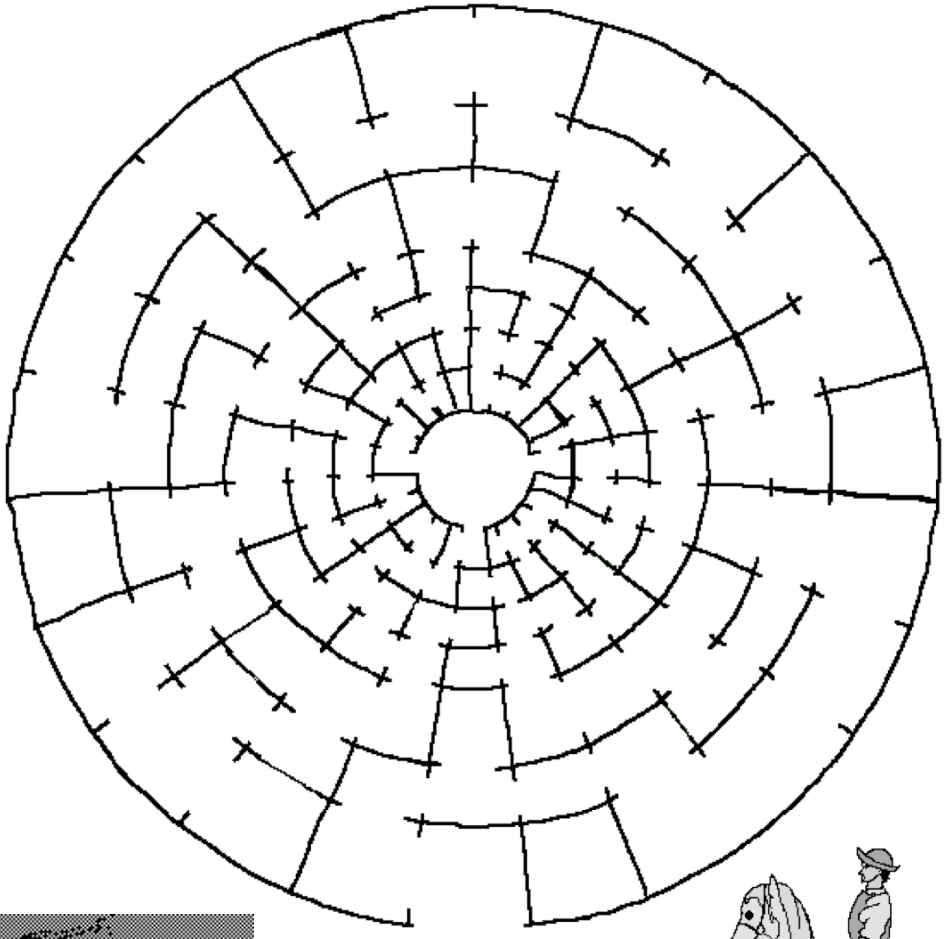
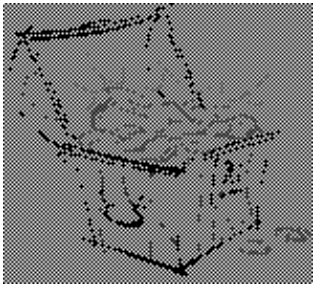
Tenochtitlan Mexico City Cancun





Cortez

G-17

Help Cortez get to the center of the maze.

Cortez's success with the conquest of the Aztec empire made him a hero in Spain. He became very powerful and was able to gain immense wealth from the gold acquired in his conquest. He became the of New Spain in 1523. However, Cortez was not finished exploring the New World. In 1524, Cortez set out for Honduras with a group of men. They stayed there for two years. Fearing Cortez was becoming corrupt with power, the King of Spain forced Cortez to give up his position as governor and return to Spain. Cortez was later allowed to return to Mexico but before he left Spain, he was stripped of his power and had much less freedom when he returned to Mexico.

1. Cortez became a hero in _____ after his conquest of the Aztecs.

2. The _____ Cortez acquired in his conquest made him extremely wealthy and powerful.

3. Cortez became the _____ of New Spain in 1523.

4. Hernando set out for _____ in 1524.

5. The King stripped Hernando of his position as governor, because he feared he was becoming _____ with power.

6. After this, he returned to _____.

Mexico	Honduras	corrupt
Spain	gold	governor

Fill in the blanks with the words from the word bank.

1. Cortez was thought of as what after his conquest of the Aztecs?

2. Where did Cortez explore in 1524?

3. What did Cortez gain from the Aztecs that made him wealthy and powerful?

4. What did the king fear was happening to Cortez with all his power?

5. Cortez was forced to return where?

6. After being stripped of his power he eventually returned where?

Word Bank

Spain	a hero	Mexico
becoming corrupt	gold	Honduras

Answer the questions using the word bank.

1. Cortez was thought of as what after his conquest of the Aztecs?

a hero

2. Where did Cortez explore in 1524?

Honduras

3. What did Cortez gain from the Aztecs that made him wealthy and powerful?

gold

4. What did the king fear was happening to Cortez with all his power?

becoming corrupt

5. Cortez was forced to return where?

Spain

6. After being stripped of his power he eventually returned where?

Mexico

Word Bank

Spain	a hero	Mexico
becoming corrupt	gold	Honduras

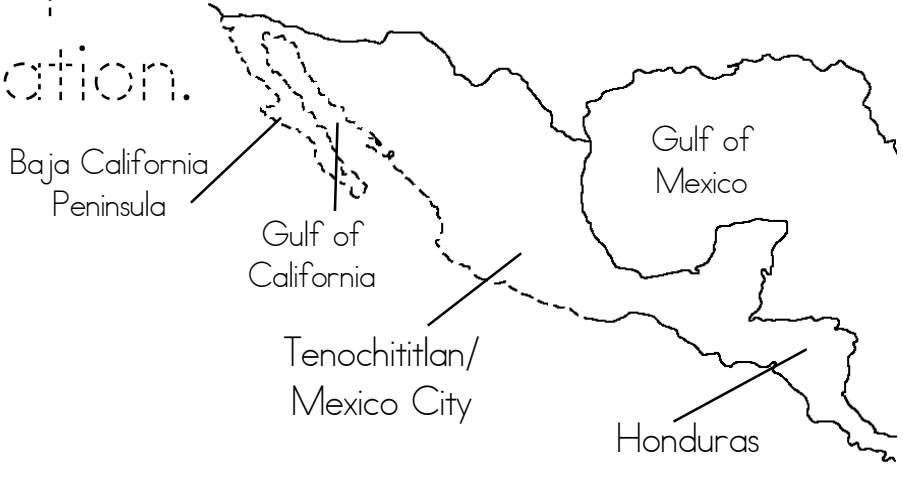
Word Bank

Cortez Mexico Aztecs Malinche Ruins
Governor Conquistad Gold Weapons
Spain Steel Horses Montezuma Corrupt
Smallpox Emperor

						Z	T	S	J						
			T	P	U	R	R	M	H	O	R	W			
		X	C	O	R	R	U	P	T	R	E	E	C		
	R	U	I	S	M	N	M	R	U	I	M	A	G	N	
	H	O	R	N	A	S	O	S	S	N	P	P	O	C	D
B	G	F	S	I	L	E	N	M	C	O	E	P	L	H	M
C	O	N	Q	U	I	S	T	A	D	O	R	O	D	E	A
J	V	O	K	R	N	M	E	L	V	H	O	R	S	E	S
T	E	P	A	Z	C	B	Z	L	O	G	R	O	T	P	L
E	R	A	D	S	H	F	U	P	X	M	C	C	E	O	O
C	N	E	R	T	E	Z	M	O	N	E	O	I	E	X	G
	O	U	Q	N	O	C	A	X	I	X	R	X	L	S	
	R	W	E	A	P	O	N	S	A	Z	T	E	C	S	
			I	N	C	A	S	M	P	R	E	M	O		
				A	Y	A	M	E	S	G	Z				

Find and circle the words from the word bank in the Word Search.

Cortez's last major voyage was to the northwestern part of Mexico. There he discovered the Baja California peninsula. During this time, he also explored the Pacific Coast of Mexico. He returned to Spain in 1534 where he spent the rest of his days. He died in 1547 near Seville. Hernando Cortez is remembered as an explorer and the conqueror of the mighty Aztec nation.



1. Cortez made his last major voyage to the northwestern part of _____.
2. During his exploration, he discovered the _____ _____.
3. Cortez also explored the _____ Coast of Mexico.
4. He returned to Spain in 1534 and died in _____.
5. Hernando Cortez is known as an e_____ and a c_____.

	Word Bank	
Baja		Mexico
explorer	1547	Peninsula
Pacific		conquistador

Fill in the blanks using the words from the Word Bank.

1. Where was Cortez's last major voyage?

_____

2. What did he discover on his last voyage?

_____

3. What other area did he explore during this time?

_____

4. During what year did Cortez return to Spain for the last time?

_____

5. In what year did Cortez die?

_____

Answer Bank

a) Baja Peninsula

b) 1547

c) Pacific Coast of Mexico

d) Northwestern region of Mexico

e) 1539

Fill in the blanks with the correct letter from the answer bank.

1. Where was Cortez's last major voyage?

_____ **d**

2. What did he discover on his last voyage?

_____ **a**

3. What other area did he explore during this time?

_____ **c**

4. During what year did Cortez return to Spain for the last time?

_____ **e**

5. In what year did Cortez die?

_____ **b**

Answer Bank

a) Baja Peninsula

b) 1547

c) Pacific Coast of Mexico

d) Northwestern region of Mexico

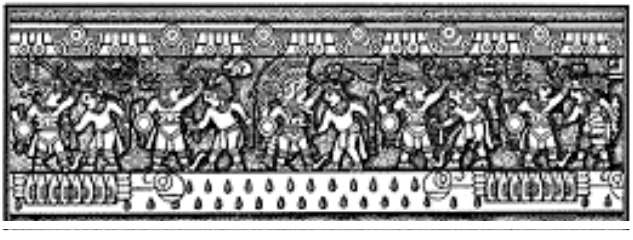
e) 1539

Cortez

G-27

Find the four hidden pictures within the picture above.

Hernando Cortez was a Spanish conquistador most famous for the overthrow of the powerful Aztec empire. His conquest began with the suppression of the town of Tabasco. There he met his friend, Malinche, who later enabled him to communicate and form alliances with the native people. With the help of the Tlaxcala Indians Cortez penetrated the Aztec empire. Montezuma and his people believed Cortez was the mythic god, Quetzalcoatl. Cortez took Montezuma hostage believing his people would not revolt without their leader. The Aztec people betrayed their emperor and stoned him to death. Cortez's attempt to take the empire failed.



Cortez returned a second time to defeat the Aztecs. This time the Aztecs were weakened by smallpox and were no match for the modern weapons of the Spaniards. They were easily overcome and Cortez was victorious. Over the ruins of the empire, Cortez built Mexico City and became very wealthy and powerful from the Aztec gold. He was appointed Governor of New Spain. His voyages continued into the lands of Honduras. The King of Spain stripped him of his title of governor and most of his freedom. He had to return to Spain. Eventually, Cortez returned to Mexico and on his last voyage he discovered the Baja Peninsula of California. He later returned to Spain and died in 1547 near Seville.

1. What is Hernando Cortez best know for?

2. Why did the Aztec people allow Cortez into Montezuma's palace?

3. How did Cortez and his men defeat the Aztecs on their second attempt?

Answer each question in complete sentences.

4. What effect did the conquest have on Cortez's reputation and status?

5. How did the King of Spain feel about Cortez when he began exploring Honduras?

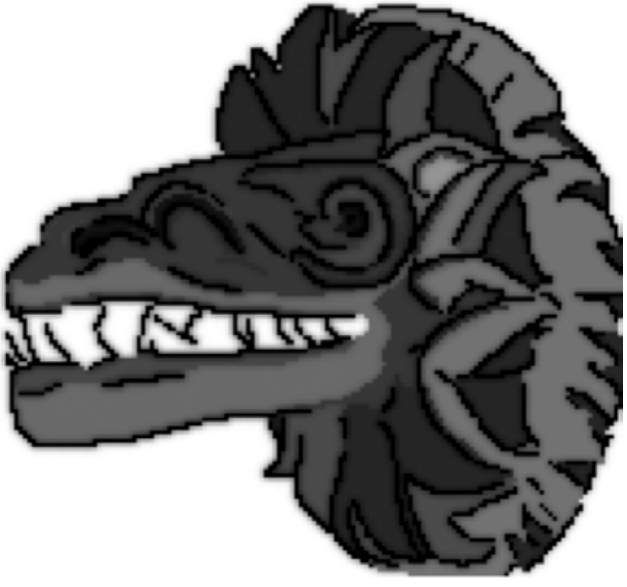
6. What other lands did Cortez explore?

Answer each question in complete sentences.

The Aztec people worshiped many gods.

This is a depiction of the mythic god, Quetzalcoatl.

The Aztecs believed Cortez was this god.



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